Employment Equity Snapshot 2024: Workforce Structure, Employers and Locations

Summary

Employment in the dataset is concentrated and top-heavy in the wrong places. Half of all employees work in the private sector, but a single provincial education department accounts for more than a third of the whole workforce, which shapes several of the averages below. Top and senior management make up under 2% of employees. Ten employers hold 59% of all jobs, and ten towns and cities host 80%. Foreign nationals are only 1.1% of the workforce, with nearly half of them in just two sectors.

1. Where Employees Work

	city_town	province	employers	employees
1	PIETERMARITZBURG	KWAZULU NATAL	5	131147
2	JOHANNESBURG	GAUTENG	62	59221
3	DURBAN	KWAZULU NATAL	28	30743
4	PRETORIA	GAUTENG	47	23621
5	CAPE TOWN	WESTERN CAPE	28	18852
6	GERMISTON	GAUTENG	8	5584
7	CENTURION	GAUTENG	10	5207
8	TONGAAT	KWAZULU NATAL	3	3954
9	MIDRAND	GAUTENG	7	3566
10	CERES	WESTERN CAPE	6	3272

The ten locations hold 285,167 employees, about 80% of the total. Pietermaritzburg ranks first only because it hosts the Department of Education, which accounts for 99.4% of its headcount. By employer base, Johannesburg is the real centre: 62 employers and 59,221 employees, followed by Pretoria (47 employers) and then Durban and Cape Town (28 each). Gauteng supplies five of the ten locations, KwaZulu-Natal three and the Western Cape two.

2. Largest Employers and Their Female Headcount

	ee_ref	employer_name	industry_sector	province	employees	pct_female
1	aa49efde7c5a2d453c9ad70aaf824b8b	KWAZULU NATAL PROVINCIALDEPARTMENT OF EDUCATION	ARTS, ENTERTAINMENT AND RECREATION	KWAZULU NATAL	130309	74.0
2	fcf78fdb6dcc946e7383c4a912a817d9	SMOLLAN GROUP SA (PTY) LTD	WHOLESALE AND RETAIL TRADE; REPAIR OF MOTOR VEHI...	GAUTENG	24627	51.1
3	42e4d6ea47aabc072a28ad0227b94...	ETHEKWINI MUNICIPALITY	PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION AND DEFENCE; COMPULSORY S...	KWAZULU NATAL	24297	45.4
4	0342238ddc5e10db0853113876d26...	WBHO CONSTRUCTION (PTY) LTD	CONSTRUCTION	GAUTENG	6237	17.5
5	8a53f4efa90f75b4ba56c825da22eabe	SANTAM L IMITED	FINANCIAL AND INSURANCE ACTIVITIES	WESTERN CAPE	6093	56.7
6	9b73e248aa22820f80d9103cd96f8480	LIBERTY GROUP LIMITED	FINANCIAL AND INSURANCE ACTIVITIES	GAUTENG	4652	60.7
7	9e3e2a72ec91d2fa4b874e996e1621f0	EXXARO COAL (PTY) LTD	MINING AND QUARRYING	GAUTENG	4410	31.8
8	d8ab5aa79362bd369d62e9f291d6af78	PEPKOR TRADING (PTY) LTD	WHOLESALE AND RETAIL TRADE; REPAIR OF MOTOR VEHI...	GAUTENG	4199	54.1
9	911fbac240acd87b368f4b5a840008d8	SITA (PTY) LTD	INFORMATION AND COMMUNICATION	GAUTENG	3451	47.4
10	c90333bba4b4f729af0a9d01cb7ede8b	SEA HARVEST CORPORATION PTY LTD	MANUFACTURING	WESTERN CAPE	3254	33.3

The ten largest employers account for 211,529 employees, 59.3% of the total. The Department of Education alone is 36.5%, and the top three together are just over half (50.2%). Six of the ten are in Gauteng, two in KwaZulu-Natal and two in the Western Cape.

Women's share ranges from 17.5% at WBHO Construction to 74.0% at the Department of Education. The three lowest, WBHO, Exxaro (31.8%) and Sea Harvest (33.3%), are in construction, mining and manufacturing. The Department of Education is recorded under Arts, Entertainment and Recreation, which looks like a misclassification and also makes that sector's totals unusually large.

3. Employment By Business Type and Their Female Headcount

	business_type	employers	employees	pct_female_all_levels	pct_female_senior_leadership	pct_temporary
1	Private Sector	463	181185	41.1	30.1	10.6
2	Educational Institution	7	132720	73.7	50.0	24.2
3	Local Government	9	29267	44.3	40.1	3.9
4	State Owned Enterpr...	4	7686	48.4	36.4	6.5
5	Non-Profit Organizat...	14	3773	48.7	35.6	1.5
6	Provincial Governme...	1	1779	54.5	56.6	13.2
7	National Government	2	575	55.1	49.6	1.2

The private sector holds 463 of the 500 employers and 50.8% of employees. Educational institutions are only seven employers, yet they employ 132,720 people, and 130,309 of those belong to one employer, the KwaZulu-Natal Provincial Department of Education. Their high female share (73.7%) and high temporary share (24.2%) therefore largely describe that single employer.

In every business type except the provincial government, which is a single employer, women hold a smaller share of senior leadership than of the workforce overall. The gap is about 11 points in the private sector and 12 to 13 points among state-owned enterprises and non-profits.

4. Foreign National Employees By Sector

	industry_sector	foreign_nationals	employees	pct_foreign_nationals
1	INFORMATION AND COMMUNICATION	855	7501	11.4
2	AGRICULTURE, FORESTRY & FISHING	993	22114	4.5
3	EDUCATION	144	3943	3.7
4	ACCOMMODATION AND FOOD SERVI...	199	5639	3.5
5	ADMINISTRATIVE AND SUPPORT AC...	196	6483	3.0
6	PROFESSIONAL, SCIENTIFIC AND TE...	82	4609	1.8
7	FINANCIAL AND INSURANCE ACTIVITI...	255	15249	1.7
8	CONSTRUCTION	169	12732	1.3
9	MINING AND QUARRYING	192	14245	1.3
10	REAL ESTATE ACTIVITIES	8	615	1.3
11	ELECTRICITY, GAS, STEAM AND AIR ...	18	1559	1.2
12	TRANSPORTATION AND STORAGE	134	12374	1.1
13	HUMAN HEALTH AND SOCIAL WORK...	48	4921	1.0
14	MANUFACTURING	298	36842	0.8
15	WHOLESALE AND RETAIL TRADE; R...	168	45833	0.4
16	PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION AND DEFE...	5	28345	0.0
17	ARTS, ENTERTAINMENT AND RECR...	45	132121	0.0
18	WATER SUPPLY; SEWERAGE, WAST...	0	1860	0.0

The table shows the seven sectors with the highest shares; the remaining eleven are all at 1.3% or below. Across all sectors there are 3,809 foreign nationals, 1.1% of the workforce. Information and Communication has the highest share (11.4%), and Agriculture, Forestry and Fishing has the highest count (993). Those two sectors employ 8.3% of all workers but 48.5% of all foreign nationals. Water supply reports none, and Public Administration and Arts, Entertainment and Recreation round to 0.0%. The Arts figure is diluted by the Department of Education's classification noted above.

5. Workforce Structure By Occupation Level

	occupation_level	no_of_employees	pct_of_workforce
1	Skilled technical and academically qualified work...	129276	36.2
2	Semi-skilled and discretionary decision making	90741	25.4
3	Temporary employees	53278	14.9
4	Unskilled and defined decision making	39747	11.1
5	Professionally qualified and experienced speciali...	37290	10.4
6	Senior management	5139	1.4
7	Top management	1514	0.4

Skilled technical staff form the largest group, and semi-skilled and unskilled roles together make up 36.5% of employees. Temporary employees (14.9%) outnumber professionally qualified specialists and mid-managers (10.4%). Top and senior management total 6,653 people, or 1.9% of the workforce.